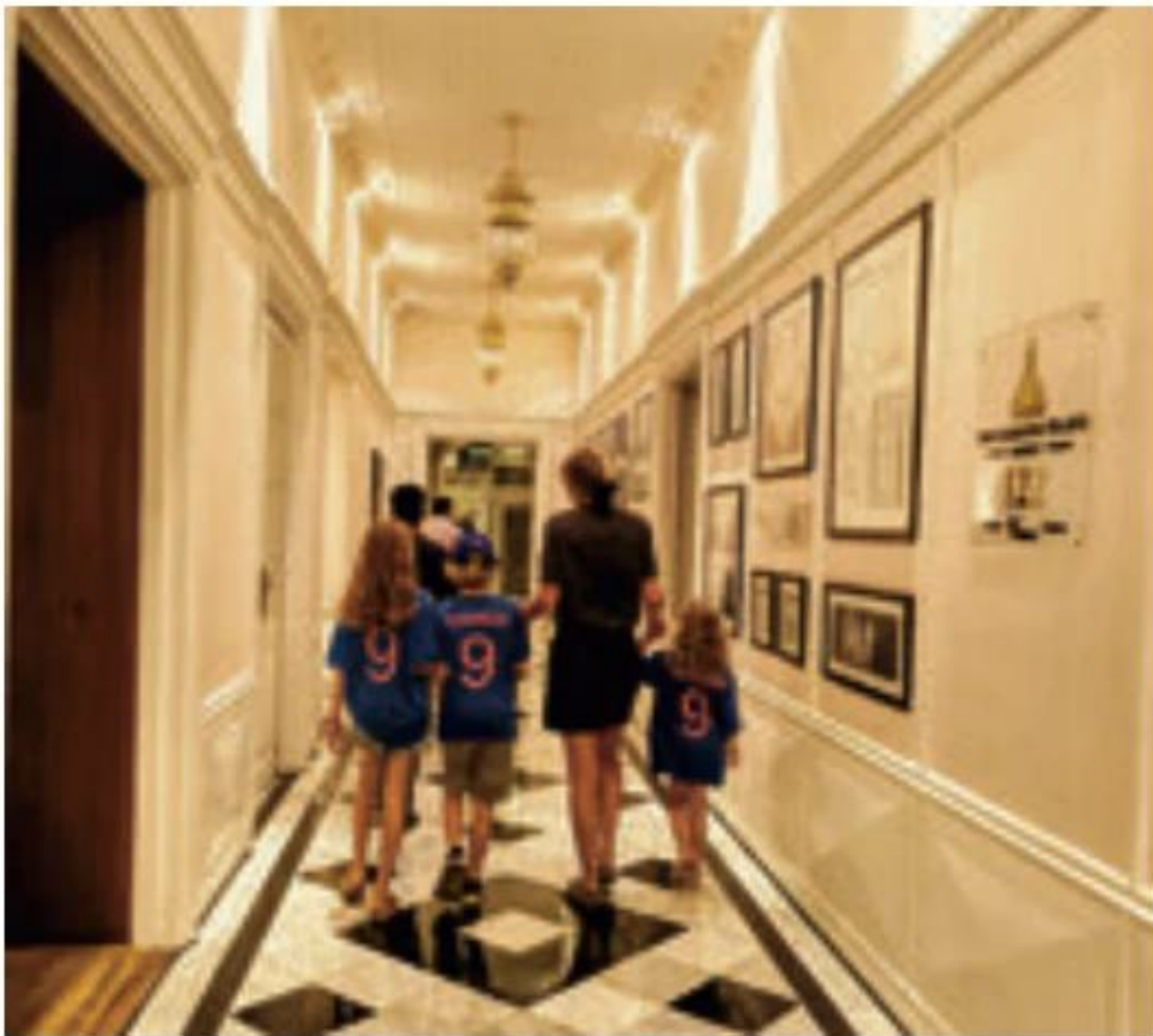


Between applause and **afterglow**

PICS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Starry night

Three children in Sanju Samson jerseys sat by the staircase of the Taj Mahal Palace ballroom, waiting for an autograph that seemed unlikely. The Sportstar Aces Awards had ended, and their mother, Christina, lingered in the lobby until 11 pm, chasing a final bit of luck.

When she asked if any cricketer was still around, the odds were slim. Yet, inside the lounge were Glenn McGrath, Sunil Gavaskar and several former India women's captains. The family was led in, and what followed was effortless generosity, photos, smiles and signatures on India jerseys.

Then came an unexpected turn. Spotting a Sportstar cover featuring hockey player Pritam Siwach, Christina asked if she was present. She was. The two, both former internationals, slipped into conversation, joined by M. M. Somaya, sharing memories across eras and continents.

For a few minutes, the night moved beyond awards. A family left with something rarer than autographs, a sense of belonging in a distant land.

"Too slow, mate"

The elevator hummed its way down 17 floors, carrying a handful of strangers bound briefly by shared gravity and direction. Inside, the writer found himself revisiting a familiar fascination, no longer about mechanics, but about the quiet choreography of people in confined spaces.

Polite nods, half-smiles, and averted eyes filled the silence until the doors opened again. A tall Australian stepped in, his face unmistakable, even if no one said it aloud.

The quiet held until the next stop. Two men outside argued over entering, one restraining the other, as an outstretched arm inside kept the doors from closing. Seconds passed, tension lingering.

Then came a calm voice beside the writer.

"Hey mate, if you don't mind... we are in a bit of a hurry."

The man paused, recognition flickering too late as the doors slid shut.

"Yeah, too slow, mate. Too slow," said Glenn McGrath.

This time, the silence broke. Laughter filled the lift.

An exception, earned

Sunil Gavaskar is known to guard his meal times, a rare private pause in a public life. Autographs and photographs can wait. Dinner cannot.

So what unfolded at the Taj Mahal Palace's Emerald Room felt special.

After the Sportstar Aces Awards, Gavaskar was having dinner with Nari Contractor and his family. But Olympic silver medallist Saikhom Mirabai Chanu had one wish, a photograph with him, relayed through Sportstar editor Ayon Sengupta.

Gavaskar smiled and set aside his rule.

For an Olympic medallist, he said, an exception was only right. Moments later, greatness met greatness in a simple photograph.

